



Striped skunk

Mephites mephites

About the size of a domestic cat, the striped skunk is related to badgers, otters, and weasels. Skunks share features such as a stocky, low-slung body with them, but have the ability to spray a noxious chemical at potential predators. This fluid is produced by the anal scent glands under the tail. The skunk first lifts its tail in the air like a flag and stamps the ground as a warning. Should the aggressor stand its ground, the skunk does a handstand, twists its body, and squirts the liquid over its head at the attacker's face.

Opportunistic feeder

The striped skunk lives in a wide variety of habitats, often near water. It will eat virtually anything, including household garbage. Mostly solitary and nocturnal, it can sometimes be spotted in the half-light of dawn and dusk. Striped skunks breed from February to March; females give birth in a burrow or a den underneath a building or fallen tree. The young become independent at about seven or eight weeks.

▷ WARNING COLORATION

The skunk's striking black-and-white coloration with a bold white "V" running down its back and tail, and its raised tail, serve as a warning to potential predators.



△ NEST RAIDER

A striped skunk forages in a wild turkey's nest. Skunks are adept at finding bird eggs, and often eat an entire clutch at one go.

long, bushy tail



- ↔ 22–30 in (56–76 cm)
- ⚖ 6–14 lb (2.7–6.4 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🍷 Rodents, bird eggs, honey
- 🏠



C. Canada to N. Mexico

- ↔ 4–6 ft (1.2–1.8 m)
- ⚖ 120–660 lb (55–300 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🍷 Fruit, nuts, vegetation
- 🏠



North America, N. Central America